



The Battle of Nancy was the final and decisive Burgundian War, which left thousands dead, including the Duke of Burgundy, Charles the Bold.

“IT IS NOT NECESSARY TO HOPE IN ORDER TO UNDERTAKE, NOR TO SUCCEED IN ORDER TO PERSEVERE.”

Charles the Bold, Duke of Burgundy (1433–77)

The Ottomans continued their expansion with the **Treaty of Constantinople** of 1479, which ended the intermittent Ottoman–Venetian war that had begun in 1463. It confirmed the **Ottomans as a naval power** of growing importance. It also brought with it Ottoman control of the Greek island **Negroponte (Euobea)** and of Lemnos in the north Aegean. **Venice** remained a major power in much of the region but it was anxious not to jeopardize its lucrative Ottoman trading links.

The accession of **Isabella I** to the throne of Castile in 1474 was challenged by her step-niece,

Joan, wife of King Afonso V of Portugal, in part to disrupt Castilian claims in the exploration of the West African coast. At its heart was a dispute as to which country could lay claim to the Atlantic island groups—the Canaries, the Azores, and Madeira—successively colonized by Spain and Portugal since the early 15th century. The outcome was the 1479 **Treaty of Alcáçovas**, confirming Castile’s claims to the Canaries and Portugal’s claims to the Azores and Madeira, and Portuguese rights in West Africa.

THE SPANISH INQUISITION

Founded by Ferdinand and Isabella in 1478, the goal of the Inquisition was to impose an overarching Christian Catholic identity on all Spanish territories. Tribunals were held in which heretics—which at this time meant Jews and those who had converted to Christianity from Judaism—were punished and expelled. After the fall of Granada in 1492, it was also applied to Muslims. The Inquisition was finally disbanded in 1820.



Built in 1482 as São Jorge da Mina, Elmina Castle was one of the first Portuguese trading forts on the west coast of Africa (now Ghana).

BY ABOUT 1440, THREE SEPARATE **MOSSI KINGDOMS** had become established in West Africa, roughly in present-day Burkina Faso. These were Tengkodogo, Yatenga, and Wogodogo. Making use of formidable cavalry, from about 1480 they exploited the **gradual decline of Mali** in the face of **Songhay expansion** by raiding deep into Mali territories. They would remain an important presence until colonization by France some 400 years later.

The year 1482 saw two crucial developments in the continuing **Portuguese exploration** and settlement of **West Africa**. The first was the construction of **São Jorge da Mina**, now called Elmina Castle, on what was later known as the **Gold Coast** and is today **Ghana**. It was a strongly fortified trading post, built on royal authority and the first permanent European settlement in

sub-Saharan Africa, designed to secure a Portuguese monopoly of the **West African gold trade**. It proved immensely lucrative. By the early 16th century, 1,500lb (680kg) of gold a year were passing through Elmina.

The second development was a further series of voyages, led by **Diogo Cão**, southward along the West African coast. The voyages were sponsored by the new king of Portugal, **John II, who came to the throne in 1481** and who committed his country to a deliberately aggressive policy of Portuguese expansion. On **Cão’s first voyage**, in 1482, he reached—and claimed for Portugal—the mouth of the Congo. On his second voyage, in 1484–86, he penetrated almost a farther **1,000 miles (1,600 km) south** to Walvis Bay (now in Namibia), once again imperiously claiming the coast in the name of



Cão’s cross

Portuguese explorer **Diogo Cão** marked his discoveries of the west coast of Africa with a series of imposing stone crosses.

the **Portuguese throne**. Both voyages were epics of tenacity, made in the face of consistently unfavorable winds and currents. This was a discouraging discovery. Where sailing conditions around **West Africa to the Gulf of Guinea** were generally benign, aided by northeast trade winds and the Guinea Current, to the south they were much more arduous. Cão’s achievement was impressive, but it emphasized that if a practical route existed to the Indian Ocean and the East, it would be left to later Portuguese navigators—notably **Bartolomeu Dias** in 1487—to pioneer the new route, deep into the **South Atlantic**.



87
THE NUMBER
OF BOOKS
PUBLISHED BY
CAXTON’S
PRESS

1477 William Caxton publishes first book from London printing press

January 4, 1478 City of Novgorod, surrenders to Ivan III

November 1, 1478 Spanish Inquisition founded

September 4, 1479 Treaty of Alcáçovas confirms Portuguese and Castile claims in West Africa and Atlantic island groups

January 25, 1479 Peace of Constantinople: Venice cedes Lemnos and coastal Albania to Ottomans

1480 Ludovico Sforza becomes regent of Milan (to 1499)

1480 Civil war in north Maya states

May 3, 1481 Death of Mehmed II (b. 1432), the Conqueror; accession of Bayezid II

1481 Mali empire weakens in face of raids by Mossi

1482 First Portuguese trading fort, São Jorge da Mina (Elmina), West Africa, built

1482 West African voyages of Diogo Cão begin (to 1486)

December 23, 1482 Treaty of Arras: Burgundy and Anjou absorbed into France